

Chapter 4 — Jñāna-Karma-Sannyāsa Yoga

ज्ञानकर्मसंन्यासयोगः : జ్ఞానకర్మసంన్యాసయోగము

"The Yoga of Renunciation of Action through Knowledge" · 42 verses · Detailed verse-by-verse edition with Ādi-Śaṅkara's Bhāṣya

Having taught karma-yoga in Chapter 3, Kṛṣṇa now reveals its **ancient lineage** and its **true fruit — knowledge (jñāna)**. The title captures Śaṅkara's whole thesis: this chapter is about the *renunciation of action through knowledge*.

Its climax (4.18–4.24, 4.33, 4.37–4.38) is the doctrine that **all action culminates in knowledge**, and that the wise one "sees inaction in action." The renunciation taught here is **internal and epistemic**: one does not necessarily drop the activity — one drops the false *sense of agency* ("I am the doer") by *knowing* the Self to be the actionless witness.

Devanāgarī

IAST

English translation

Śaṅkara's Bhāṣya (explanation)

§ 1 · The lineage of this yoga & the doctrine of avatāra (4.1–4.8)

BG 4.1 *An imperishable, royal lineage*

श्रीभगवानुवाच ।

इमं विवस्वते योगं प्रोक्तवानहमव्ययम् ।

विवस्वान्मनवे प्राह मनुर्िक्ष्वाकवेऽब्रवीत् ॥ ४.१ ॥

*śrī-bhagavān uvāca | imam vivasvate yogam proktavān aham avyayam |
vivasvān manave prāha manur ikṣvākave 'bravīt | |*

The Lord: "I taught this imperishable yoga to Vivasvān (the Sun); Vivasvān told it to Manu; Manu told it to Ikṣvāku."

Bhāṣya: This yoga is ancient and unbroken — passed down a royal lineage (*rāja-ṛṣi paramparā*). Its transmission through great kings underscores its authority and its suitability for those *engaged in action*, not only recluses.

BG 4.2 *Lost over the long course of time*

एवं परम्पराप्राप्तमिमं राजर्षयो विदुः ।

स कालेनेह महता योगो नष्टः परन्तप ॥ ४.२ ॥

*evam paramparā-prāptam imam rājarṣayo viduḥ |
sa kāleneha mahatā yogo naṣṭaḥ parantapa | |*

"Thus received in succession, the royal sages knew it. But in the long course of time, that yoga was lost, O scorcher of foes."

Bhāṣya: Through weak custodians and inattention the teaching decayed — which is why Kṛṣṇa must restate it now.

BG 4.3 *The supreme secret, given to the fit*

स एवायं मया तेऽद्य योगः प्रोक्तः पुरातनः ।

भक्तोऽसि मे सखा चेति रहस्यं ह्येतदुत्तमम् ॥ ४.३ ॥

*sa evāyam mayā te 'dya yogaḥ proktaḥ purātanaḥ |
bhakto 'si me sakhā ceti rahasyam hy etad uttamam | |*

"That same ancient yoga I have declared to you today, for you are My devotee and friend; this is the supreme secret."

Bhāṣya: Fitness matters. The teaching is given because Arjuna is a *devotee and friend* — qualified by devotion and nearness. This knowledge is a "supreme secret," granted only to the fit.

अर्जुन उवाच ।

अपरं भवतो जन्म परं जन्म विवस्वतः ।

कथमेतद्विजानीयां त्वमादौ प्रोक्तवानिति ॥ ४.४ ॥

*arjuna uvāca | aparaṁ bhavato janma paraṁ janma vivasvataḥ |
katham etad vijāntīyāṁ tvam ādau proktavān iti | |*

Arjuna: "Your birth was later; Vivasvān's was earlier. How am I to understand that You taught this in the beginning?"

Bhāṣya: A natural doubt, taking Kṛṣṇa as an ordinary man recently born. This objection sets up the great teaching on divine incarnation.

श्रीभगवानुवाच ।

बहूनि मे व्यतीतानि जन्मानि तव चार्जुन ।

तान्यहं वेद सर्वाणि न त्वं वेत्थ परन्तप ॥ ४.५ ॥

*śrī-bhagavān uvāca | bahūni me vyatītāni janmāni tava cārjuna |
tāny ahaṁ veda sarvāṇi na tvam vettha parantapa | |*

The Lord: "Many births of Mine have passed, and of yours too, Arjuna. I know them all; you do not, O scorcher of foes."

Bhāṣya: The difference between the Lord and the jīva: the Lord, ever-pure and free of *avidyā*, *knows* all His "births"; the bound soul, veiled by ignorance, forgets. The Lord's "birth" is not real bondage but *māyā*.

अजोऽपि सन्नव्ययात्मा भूतानामीश्वरोऽपि सन् ।

प्रकृतिं स्वमधिष्ठाय सम्भवाम्यात्ममायया ॥ ४.६ ॥

*ajo 'pi sann avyayātmā bhūtānām īśvaro 'pi san |
prakṛtiṁ svām adhiṣṭhāya sambhavāmy ātma-māyayā | |*

"Though I am unborn, of imperishable nature, and the Lord of all beings, yet governing My own prakṛti, I come into being by My own māyā."

Bhāṣya: Crucial for Advaita. The Lord's incarnation is *apparent*, not a real modification. He is truly unborn and changeless; He "appears" to take birth **through His own māyā** (creative power), not through karma like ordinary beings. No real loss of His nature.

यदा यदा हि धर्मस्य ग्लानिर्भवति भारत ।

अभ्युत्थानमधर्मस्य तदात्मानं सृजाम्यहम् ॥ ४.७ ॥

*yadā yadā hi dharmasya glānir bhavati bhārata |
abhyutthānam adharmasya tadātmānaṁ sṛjāmy aham | |*

"Whenever there is a decline of dharma and a rise of adharma, O Bhārata, then I manifest Myself."

Bhāṣya: The famous *avatāra* verse. When righteousness wanes and unrighteousness prevails, the Lord "sends forth" Himself — again, through māyā — to restore balance.

BG 4.8 ☐ To protect the good, destroy evil, re-establish dharma

परित्राणाय साधूनां विनाशाय च दुष्कृताम् ।
धर्मसंस्थापनार्थाय सम्भवामि युगे युगे ॥ ४.८ ॥

paritrāṇāya sādhunām vināśāya ca duṣkṛtām |
dharma-saṁsthāpanārthāya sambhavāmi yuge yuge ||

"For the protection of the good, the destruction of evildoers, and the re-establishment of dharma, I come into being age after age."

Bhāṣya: The threefold purpose of incarnation. Śaṅkara notes "protection of the good" (those who tread the right path) is the primary aim.

§ 2 · Knowing the Lord; who reaches Him; how the ancients acted (4.9–4.15)

BG 4.9 *Knowing His divine birth & action liberates*

जन्म कर्म च मे दिव्यमेवं यो वेत्ति तत्त्वतः ।

त्यक्त्वा देहं पुनर्जन्म नैति मामेति सोऽर्जुन ॥ ४.९ ॥

janma karma ca me divyam evaṁ yo veti tattvataḥ |
tyaktvā dehaṁ punar janma naiti mām eti so 'rjuna | |

"He who thus knows, in truth, the divine birth and action of Mine, on leaving the body is not born again but comes to Me, O Arjuna."

Bhāṣya: Right knowledge of the Lord's birth-and-action as *divine* (illusory, māyā-born, not karmically forced) is itself liberating. Such a knower is not reborn — he attains the Lord. Knowledge, not ritual, liberates.

BG 4.10 *Purified by the austerity of knowledge*

वीतरागभयक्रोधा मन्मया मामुपाश्रिताः ।

बहवो ज्ञानतपसा पूता मद्भावमागताः ॥ ४.१० ॥

vīta-rāga-bhaya-krodhā man-mayā mām upāśritāḥ |
bahavo jñāna-tapasā pūtā mad-bhāvam āgatāḥ | |

"Freed from attachment, fear, and anger, absorbed in Me, taking refuge in Me, purified by the austerity of knowledge, many have attained My being."

Bhāṣya: The qualifications for liberation: free of *rāga*, *bhaya*, *krodha*; wholly absorbed in the Lord; purified by *jñāna-tapas* (knowledge as austerity). "Attaining My being" = becoming one with Brahman.

BG 4.11 *As they approach Me, so I favor them*

ये यथा मां प्रपद्यन्ते तांस्तथैव भजाम्यहम् ।

मम वर्त्मानुवर्तन्ते मनुष्याः पार्थ सर्वशः ॥ ४.११ ॥

ye yathā mām prapadyante tāṁs tathaiva bhajāmy aham |
mama vartmānuvartante manuṣyāḥ pārtha sarvaśaḥ | |

"In whatever way people approach Me, so do I favor them; men follow My path in all ways, O Pārtha."

Bhāṣya: The Lord responds to each according to their approach and desire — impartial, granting fruits in proportion to worship. All human paths ultimately lead toward Him.

BG 4.12 *Quick but perishable fruit of ritual*

काङ्क्षन्तः कर्मणां सिद्धिं यजन्त इह देवताः ।

क्षिप्रं हि मानुषे लोके सिद्धिर्भवति कर्मजा ॥ ४.१२ ॥

kāṅkṣantaḥ karmaṇāṁ siddhiṁ yajanta iha devatāḥ |
kṣipraṁ hi mānuṣe loke siddhir bhavati karma-jā | |

"Desiring success in action, people here worship the gods; for quickly in the human world does success born of action come."

Bhāṣya: Those craving quick worldly results worship deities and gain speedy but *limited*, *action-born* fruits — contrasted with the higher, imperishable pursuit of knowledge.

§ 3 · The heart of the chapter — "inaction in action" (4.16–4.24)

BG 4.16 Even the wise are confused about action

किं कर्म किमकर्मेति कवयोऽप्यत्र मोहिताः ।

तत्ते कर्म प्रवक्ष्यामि यज्ज्ञात्वा मोक्षयसेऽशुभात् ॥ ४.१६ ॥

*kiṁ karma kim akarmeti kavayo 'py atra mohitāḥ |
tat te karma pravakṣyāmi yaj jñātvā mokṣayase 'śubhāt ||*

"What is action? What is inaction? Even the wise are confused about this. I shall explain that action, knowing which you will be freed from evil."

Bhāṣya: A subtle, difficult topic — so subtle that even the learned are deluded. Right understanding of *karma* / *akarma* liberates from *aśubha* (evil, i.e., bondage/saṁsāra).

BG 4.17 Deep is the path of action

कर्मणो ह्यपि बोद्धव्यं बोद्धव्यं च विकर्मणः ।

अकर्मणश्च बोद्धव्यं गहना कर्मणो गतिः ॥ ४.१७ ॥

*karmaṇo hy api boddhavyaṁ boddhavyaṁ ca vikarmaṇaḥ |
akarmaṇaś ca boddhavyaṁ gahanā karmaṇo gatiḥ ||*

"One must understand action, and also forbidden action (vikarma), and inaction; deep is the path of action."

Bhāṣya: Three things must be discerned: *karma* (right action), *vikarma* (prohibited action), and *akarma* (inaction). The truth about action is *profound* (*gahanā*) — the deepest point being to recognize the actionless Self within action.

BG 4.18 ☐ The summit: seeing inaction in action

कर्मण्यकर्म यः पश्येदकर्मणि च कर्म यः ।

स बुद्धिमान्मनुष्येषु स युक्तः कृत्स्नकर्मकृत् ॥ ४.१८ ॥

*karmaṇy akarma yaḥ paśyed akarmaṇi ca karma yaḥ |
sa buddhimān manuṣyeṣu sa yuktaḥ kṛtsna-karma-kṛt ||*

"He who sees inaction in action, and action in inaction, is wise among men; he is a yogin who has done all action."

Bhāṣya: The summit of the chapter. The Self is actionless; all action belongs to prakṛti. The wise one **sees inaction in action** — the Self does nothing even while the body works; and **action in inaction** — the ego, even while "doing nothing," is still falsely engaged in agency. This *seeing* is liberating knowledge itself. (The epistemic renunciation.)

BG 4.19 ☐ Actions burnt in the fire of knowledge

यस्य सर्वे समारम्भाः कामसङ्कल्पवर्जिताः ।

ज्ञानाग्निदग्धकर्माणं तमाहुः पण्डितं बुधाः ॥ ४.१९ ॥

*yasya sarve samārambhāḥ kāma-saṅkalpa-varjitāḥ |
jñānāgni-dagdha-karmāṇaṁ tam āhuḥ paṇḍitaṁ budhāḥ ||*

"He whose undertakings are all free from desire and selfish intention, whose actions are burnt in the fire of knowledge — him the wise call a sage (paṇḍita)."

Bhāṣya: The sage's actions, done without desire or *saṅkalpa* (willful intent for results), are "burnt in the fire of knowledge" — their binding potency destroyed by the realization "I am not the doer."

BG 4.20 □ Busy in action, yet "does nothing at all"

त्यक्त्वा कर्मफलासङ्गं नित्यतृप्तो निराश्रयः ।

कर्मण्यभिप्रवृत्तोऽपि नैव किञ्चित्करोति सः ॥ ४.२० ॥

tyaktvā karma-phalāsaṅgaṁ nitya-tr̥pto nirāśrayaḥ |
karmaṇy abhipravṛtto 'pi naiva kiñcit karoti saḥ ||

"Having abandoned attachment to the fruits of action, ever content, dependent on nothing — though fully engaged in action, he does nothing at all."

Bhāṣya: Even while outwardly busy, the knower "does nothing," having renounced doership and desire for fruit. *Nitya-tr̥pta* — ever-content, needing no external support. The clearest statement of freedom-in-action.

BG 4.21 Action merely with the body, no sin

निराशीर्यतचित्तात्मा त्यक्तसर्वपरिग्रहः ।

शारीरं केवलं कर्म कुर्वन्नाप्नोति किल्बिषम् ॥ ४.२१ ॥

nirāśīr yata-cittātmā tyakta-sarva-parigrahaḥ |
śārīraṁ kevalaṁ karma kurvan nāpnoti kilbiṣam ||

"Free from expectation, mind and self controlled, having given up all possessions, performing action merely with the body, he incurs no sin."

Bhāṣya: The knower, desiring nothing, self-controlled, non-possessive, performs only bodily action (for mere maintenance, without egoistic investment). Such action accrues no sin/bondage.

BG 4.22 Content with what comes unsought

यदृच्छालाभसन्तुष्टो द्वन्द्वातीतो विमत्सरः ।

समः सिद्धावसिद्धौ च कृत्वापि न निबध्यते ॥ ४.२२ ॥

yadṛcchā-lābha-santuṣṭo dvandvātīto vimatsaraḥ |
samaḥ siddhāv asiddhau ca kṛtvāpi na nibadhyate ||

"Content with whatever comes unsought, beyond the pairs of opposites, free from envy, even-minded in success and failure — though he acts, he is not bound."

Bhāṣya: The marks of the free sage: satisfaction with whatever comes by chance, transcendence of dualities, no envy, equanimity in gain and loss. Acting from such a state cannot bind.

BG 4.23 Action dissolves entirely

गतसङ्गस्य मुक्तस्य ज्ञानावस्थितचेतसः ।

यज्ञायाचरतः कर्म समग्रं प्रविलीयते ॥ ४.२३ ॥

gata-saṅgasya muktasya jñānavasthita-cetasah |
yajñāyācarataḥ karma samagraṁ pravilīyate ||

"For one free from attachment, liberated, with mind established in knowledge, acting for the sake of sacrifice — his action dissolves entirely."

Bhāṣya: For the *jñāna-niṣṭha* (established in knowledge) who acts only as *yajña* (offering, without ego), the entire karma — its residue and binding power — *dissolves away*.

BG 4.24

ब्रह्मार्पणं ब्रह्म हविर्ब्रह्माग्नौ ब्रह्मणा हुतम् ।
ब्रह्मैव तेन गन्तव्यं ब्रह्मकर्मसमाधिना ॥ ४.२४ ॥

*brahmārpaṇaṁ brahma havir brahmāgnau brahmaṇā hutam |
brahmaiva tena gantavyaṁ brahma-karma-samādhinā ||*

"The offering is Brahman; the oblation is Brahman; offered by Brahman into the fire of Brahman. He who thus sees all as Brahman reaches Brahman alone."

Bhāṣya: The supreme vision of the knower-of-Brahman: the act of offering, the offered, the fire, and the offerer are *all Brahman*. For one absorbed in this "action-that-is-Brahman" (*brahma-karma-samādhi*), the goal attained can only be **Brahman**. Action is wholly transmuted into knowledge.

§ 4 · The many kinds of yajña; knowledge as the highest (4.25–4.33)

BG 4.25 Ritual sacrifice vs. sacrifice into Brahman

दैवमेवापरे यज्ञं योगिनः पर्युपासते ।

ब्रह्माग्नावपरे यज्ञं यज्ञेनैवोपजुहति ॥ ४.२५ ॥

*daivam evāpare yajñam yoginaḥ paryupāsate |
brahmāgnāv apare yajñam yajñenaivopajuhvati ||*

"Some yogins offer sacrifice to the gods; others offer the very self as sacrifice into the fire of Brahman."

Bhāṣya: He begins listing varied "sacrifices." Some perform ritual worship of deities (karma-yogins); others (knowers) offer the *self* into Brahman — realizing the identity of self and Brahman. The second is the sacrifice of *knowledge*.

BG 4.26 Senses into restraint; objects into the senses

श्रोत्रादीनीन्द्रियाण्यन्ये संयमाग्निषु जुहति ।

शब्दादीन्विषयानन्य इन्द्रियाग्निषु जुहति ॥ ४.२६ ॥

*śrotrādīnīndriyāṇy anye saṁyamāgniṣu juhvati |
śabdādīn viṣayān anya indriyāgniṣu juhvati ||*

"Some offer hearing and the other senses into the fires of restraint; others offer sound and the other sense-objects into the fires of the senses."

Bhāṣya: Two more "sacrifices": ascetics who offer the senses into the fire of *self-restraint* (withdrawing them); and others who, unattached, offer sense-objects into the senses (engaging sensibly without bondage).

BG 4.27 Sense- and prāṇa-activity into the fire of self-restraint

सर्वाणीन्द्रियकर्माणि प्राणकर्माणि चापरे ।

आत्मसंयमयोगाग्नौ जुहति ज्ञानदीपिते ॥ ४.२७ ॥

*sarvāṇīndriya-karmāṇi prāṇa-karmāṇi cāpare |
ātma-saṁyama-yogāgnau juhvati jñāna-dīpite ||*

"Others offer all the functions of the senses and of the vital breath into the fire of the yoga of self-restraint, kindled by knowledge."

Bhāṣya: The yogins who still all sense- and prāṇa-activity in the fire of *ātma-saṁyama-yoga* (self-control), lit by knowledge — advanced meditators whose disciplined mind is illumined by wisdom. (Note the phrase *ātma-saṁyama* — Śaṅkara's name for Chapter 6.)

BG 4.28 Wealth, austerity, yoga, study, knowledge

द्रव्ययज्ञास्तपोयज्ञा योगयज्ञास्तथापरे ।

स्वाध्यायज्ञानयज्ञाश्च यतयः संशितव्रताः ॥ ४.२८ ॥

*dravya-yajñās tapo-yajñā yoga-yajñās tathāpare |
svādhyāya-jñāna-yajñāś ca yatayaḥ saṁśita-vratāḥ ||*

"Some offer wealth as sacrifice, some austerity, some yoga; others, ascetics of firm vows, offer scriptural study and knowledge as sacrifice."

Bhāṣya: A survey of yajñas: giving (*dravya*), austerity (*tapas*), yogic practice, study (*svādhyāya*), and knowledge (*jñāna*) — all "sacrifices" by strict-vowed seekers, leading toward purification.

अपाने जुह्वति प्राणं प्राणेऽपानं तथापरे ।

प्राणापानगती रुद्ध्वा प्राणायामपरायणाः ॥ ४.२९ ॥

apāne juhvati prāṇam prāṇe 'pānam tathāpare |
prāṇāpāna-gatī ruddhvā prāṇāyāma-parāyaṇāḥ | |

"Others, devoted to prāṇāyāma, offer the outgoing breath into the incoming, and the incoming into the outgoing, restraining the flow of both."

Bhāṣya: The *prāṇāyāma* practitioners' "sacrifice": regulating and offering *prāṇa* and *apāna* into one another (pūraka, recaka, kumbhaka). Breath-control as a form of yajña.

अपरे नियताहाराः प्राणान्प्राणेषु जुह्वति ।

सर्वेऽप्येते यज्ञविदो यज्ञक्षपितकल्मषाः ॥ ४.३० ॥

apare niyatāhārāḥ prāṇān prāṇeṣu juhvati |
sarve 'py ete yajña-vido yajña-kṣapita-kalmaṣāḥ | |

"Others, of regulated diet, offer the vital breaths into the vital breaths. All these are knowers of sacrifice, their impurities destroyed by sacrifice."

Bhāṣya: Concluding the list: *all* these are "knowers of yajña," and by their sacrifices their sins/impurities are consumed. Purification is the common fruit.

यज्ञशिष्टामृतभुजो यान्ति ब्रह्म सनातनम् ।

नायं लोकोऽस्त्ययज्ञस्य कुतोऽन्यः कुरुसत्तम ॥ ४.३१ ॥

yajña-śiṣṭāmṛta-bhujo yānti brahma sanātanam |
nāyam loko 'sty ayajñasya kuto 'nyaḥ kuru-sattama | |

"Those who eat the nectar-remnant of sacrifice go to the eternal Brahman. This world is not for the non-sacrificer — how then the other, O best of the Kurus?"

Bhāṣya: Those who partake of the "immortal remnant" of yajña (its purifying fruit) reach Brahman. One who performs *no* sacrifice gains neither this world nor the next. Yajña is indispensable to any good.

एवं बहुविधा यज्ञा वितता ब्रह्मणो मुखे ।

कर्मजान्विद्धि तान्सर्वानेवं ज्ञात्वा विमोक्ष्यसे ॥ ४.३२ ॥

evam bahu-vidhā yajñā vitatā brahmaṇo mukhe |
karma-jān viddhi tān sarvān evam jñātvā vimokṣyase | |

"Thus many kinds of sacrifice are spread out in the mouth (revelation) of Brahman. Know them all to be born of action; knowing this, you will be liberated."

Bhāṣya: All these varied yajñas are sanctioned by scripture and are *born of action* (of body, speech, mind). Realizing that they are all *action* (means, not the goal), and that the goal is knowledge, one is liberated.

श्रेयान्द्रव्यमयाद्यज्ञाज्ज्ञानयज्ञः परन्तप ।

सर्वं कर्माखिलं पार्थ ज्ञाने परिसमाप्यते ॥ ४.३३ ॥

śreyān dravya-mayād yajñāj jñāna-yajñāḥ parantapa |
sarvaṁ karmākhilam pārtha jñāne parisamāpyate ||

"Better than the sacrifice of material objects is the sacrifice of knowledge, O scorcher of foes. All action, without exception, culminates in knowledge, O Pārtha."

Bhāṣya: The decisive verdict. The *jñāna-yajña* (sacrifice of knowledge) surpasses all material sacrifices. And the pivotal line — "*sarvaṁ karmākhilam... jñāne parisamāpyate*" — **all action culminates in knowledge**. Action is preparatory; knowledge is the goal in which action *terminates*. This is the doctrinal spine of Śaṅkara's whole reading.

§ 5 · How to gain knowledge; its power; the call to act (4.34–4.42)

BG 4.34 □ Approach a teacher: reverence, inquiry, service

तद्विद्धि प्रणिपातेन परिप्रश्नेन सेवया ।

उपदेक्ष्यन्ति ते ज्ञानं ज्ञानिनस्तत्त्वदर्शिनः ॥ ४.३४ ॥

*tad viddhi praṇipātena paripraśnena sevayā |
upadekṣyanti te jñānaṁ jñāninas tattva-darśinaḥ ||*

"Know that by prostration, by inquiry, and by service; the wise, the seers of truth, will teach you knowledge."

Bhāṣya: The method for gaining knowledge: approach a realized teacher (*tattva-darśī*) with (1) humble reverence (*praṇipāta*), (2) sincere questioning (*paripraśna*), and (3) service (*sevā*). Knowledge comes through a qualified guru, not on one's own.

BG 4.35 Seeing all beings in the Self, and in the Lord

यज्ज्ञात्वा न पुनर्मोहमेवं यास्यसि पाण्डव ।

येन भूतान्यशेषेण द्रक्ष्यस्यात्मन्यथो मयि ॥ ४.३५ ॥

*yaj jñātvā na punar moham evaṁ yāsyasi pāṇḍava |
yena bhūtāny aśeṣeṇa draṁsyasy ātmany atho mayi ||*

"Knowing which, you will not again fall into delusion; by which you will see all beings, without exception, in yourself, and then in Me."

Bhāṣya: The fruit of this knowledge: permanent end of delusion, and the vision of *all beings within the Self, and the Self within the Lord* — the realization of non-dual identity (*samyag-darśana*).

BG 4.36 The raft of knowledge crosses all sin

अपि चेदसि पापेभ्यः सर्वेभ्यः पापकृत्तमः ।

सर्वं ज्ञानप्लवेनैव वृजिनं सन्तरिष्यसि ॥ ४.३६ ॥

*api ced asi pāpebhyaḥ sarvebhyaḥ pāpa-kṛt-tamaḥ |
sarvaṁ jñāna-plavenaiva vṛjinaṁ santariṣyasi ||*

"Even if you were the most sinful of all sinners, you would cross over all wickedness by the raft of knowledge alone."

Bhāṣya: The unmatched power of knowledge: even the worst sinner can cross the entire ocean of *saṁsāra* by the "raft of knowledge," which destroys the very root (ignorance) from which all sins spring.

BG 4.37 □ The fire of knowledge burns all karma to ashes

यथैधांसि समिद्धोऽग्निर्भस्मसात्कुरुतेऽर्जुन ।

ज्ञानान्निः सर्वकर्माणि भस्मसात्कुरुते तथा ॥ ४.३७ ॥

*yathaidhāṁsi samiddho 'gnir bhasmasāt kurute 'rjuna |
jñānāgniḥ sarva-karmāṇi bhasmasāt kurute tathā ||*

"As a blazing fire reduces firewood to ashes, so does the fire of knowledge reduce all actions to ashes."

Bhāṣya: The famous metaphor: as fire burns fuel to ash, the **fire of knowledge** burns up all accumulated karma (except the *prārabdha* already begun) — reducing its binding power to nothing. This is why knowledge, not action, liberates.

BG 4.38 Nothing purifies like knowledge — found within

न हि ज्ञानेन सदृशं पवित्रमिह विद्यते ।
तत्त्वयं योगसंसिद्धः कालेनात्मनि विन्दति ॥ ४.३८ ॥

*na hi jñānena sadṛśam pavitram iha vidyate |
tat svayaṁ yoga-saṁsiddhaḥ kālenātmani vindati ||*

"There is nothing here as purifying as knowledge. One perfected in yoga finds it in himself, in time, of his own accord."

Bhāṣya: Nothing purifies like knowledge — the supreme *pavitra*. And it is not external: one *perfected by karma-yoga* (purified in mind) discovers this knowledge **within his own Self** in due course. Karma-yoga ripens; knowledge dawns from within.

BG 4.39 Faith → knowledge → supreme peace

श्रद्धावाँल्लभते ज्ञानं तत्परः संयतेन्द्रियः ।
ज्ञानं लब्ध्वा परां शान्तिमचिरेणाधिगच्छति ॥ ४.३९ ॥

*śraddhāvāl labhate jñānam tat-paraḥ saṁyatendriyaḥ |
jñānam labdhvā parāṁ śāntim acireṇādhigacchati ||*

"The man of faith, devoted to it, with senses restrained, gains knowledge; having gained knowledge, he swiftly attains supreme peace."

Bhāṣya: The qualifications for knowledge: *śraddhā* (faith), *tat-para* (single-minded devotion), *saṁyatendriya* (sense-control). Such a one gains knowledge and *quickly* reaches **supreme peace** (*parā śānti*). Faith is the first requisite.

BG 4.40 The doubter is ruined

अज्ञश्चाश्रद्धानश्च संशयात्मा विनश्यति ।
नायं लोकोऽस्ति न परो न सुखं संशयात्मनः ॥ ४.४० ॥

*ajñāś cāśraddadhānaś ca saṁśayaātmā vinaśyati |
nāyam loko 'sti na paro na sukham saṁśayātmanaḥ ||*

"The ignorant, the faithless, and the doubting one perishes. For the doubting soul there is neither this world, nor the next, nor happiness."

Bhāṣya: The opposite of the faithful seeker. **Doubt is the worst** — the doubting mind (*saṁśayaātmā*) enjoys neither this world, nor the next, nor any happiness. Doubt paralyzes and destroys.

BG 4.41 □ Renounced action, doubts cut, poised in the Self

योगसंन्यस्तकर्माणं ज्ञानसञ्छिन्नसंशयम् ।
आत्मवन्तं न कर्माणि निबध्नन्ति धनञ्जय ॥ ४.४१ ॥

*yoga-saṁnyasta-karmāṇaṁ jñāna-saṁchinna-saṁśayam |
ātmavantaṁ na karmāṇi nibadhnanti dhanañjaya ||*

"Actions do not bind him who has renounced action through yoga, whose doubts are cut asunder by knowledge, and who is poised in the Self, O Dhanañjaya."

Bhāṣya: The perfected one, by three marks: (1) actions renounced through yoga/knowledge; (2) all doubts severed by knowledge; (3) established in the Self — is **not bound by any action**. This ties together action-renunciation-through-knowledge — the very title of the chapter.

छित्त्वेनं संशयं योगमातिष्ठोत्तिष्ठ भारत ॥ ४.४२ ॥

Bhāṣya: The ringing conclusion. With the "sword of knowledge" (*jñāna-asī*), sever the doubt that ignorance has planted in the heart; then, established in *yoga*, **"Arise!"** — get up and fight. Knowledge cuts doubt, and the purified seeker returns to action.

→ **Continues in Chapter 5 (Karma-Sannyāsa Yoga):** Chapter 4 taught renunciation of agency *through* knowledge. Arjuna, now hearing both "act!" and "renounce through knowledge," will ask directly in 5.1: *which is better — renunciation of action, or the yoga of action?* Chapter 5 answers and reconciles the two.